Everybody Owns a Piece: Run on Real Numbers

Oct 18, 2026 · @Chris

The short answer

The bookkeeping holds. Run on what actually happened in 2021-2025, the citizen fund's share of dividends and buybacks covered its checks every year, 2022 included, by 1.04 to 1.36 times, so it never had to dip into its stake. One caveat: S&P hasn't released buybacks for the last quarter of 2025, so that quarter is an estimate.

By the end of 2025 the two trusts held 7.3% of the S&P 500, worth $3.87 trillion. Everyone's check reached $996 a year, about $83 a month, and Joe's family of four got $5,386, or $3,875 after higher carbon prices. The essay's table lands close in year one and runs low by year twenty, because the carbon fee keeps climbing.

Three things a fair economist would hammer:

1. **Somebody pays, all at once.** New shares cost companies no cash, but they move ownership away from today's owners, and the profit share cuts their profits for good. On the bookkeeping, existing shares would be worth about 28% less the day the plan looked real, or 39% less if workers leave at a typical 10% a year. At 28% that's $16.6 trillion, 29% of it held abroad and most of the rest by American households, 401(k)s and pensions included.
2. **The worker half never stops.** People leave and retire, so the worker trust keeps needing new shares. At 10% turnover the trusts take 30 years to reach a quarter, and top-ups run on at 0.83% of every company a year, for good.
3. **The floor is thinner than it looks.** Carbon is 66% of the 2025 check, and it's the piece Canada ended in 2025. At today's payout rates the fund's cash covers 88% of its 2026 checks and costs, so it sells stock most years, not just thin ones.

It's a dividend, not a UBI: $1,000 a month for everyone would take a fund twice the size of every U.S.-listed company today.

How the run works

The plan switches on January 1, 2021 and runs on what actually happened. The pieces, before any results:

- **Covered companies.** The S&P 500 stands in for everyone above the size line. Every member is far above it, and S&P publishes what they paid their owners each year, through the third quarter of 2025; the fourth is estimated here. Counting all U.S.-listed companies would add 18% to 31%; private companies aren't counted at all.
- **The share issue.** Each January 1, every covered company issues new shares worth 1.5% of itself at the prior December 31 value, half to the worker trust and half to the citizen trust, until the two hold a quarter.
- **The check.** The citizen fund pays out 3% of its January 1 value during the year, split equally among everyone the Census counts. Its cash is its share of dividends plus its share of buybacks, net of the new stock companies hand out for pay and deals. Extra cash goes into a reserve; a shortfall comes from the reserve first, then from selling stock.
- **What the plan costs the companies.** The 10% profit share comes out of the same profits that pay dividends and buybacks. Before the pay cap it takes exactly 10% of after-tax profit, a little less with it, so the run trims company values and payouts by 9%.
- **Carbon and ads.** The fee follows the Baker-Shultz path: $43 a ton in 2021, rising 5% a year above inflation. Tons are EIA's actual emissions, cut by Resources for the Future's estimate of what the fee does. The ad levy is 30% of internet ad revenue (IAB), with 80% counted as targeted; nobody measures that share, it's just what the essay's $200 needs.
- **Joe.** A $45,000 warehouse worker at Walmart, with his wife and two kids. His profit share uses Walmart's real pre-tax income and headcount. His family's carbon cost uses Treasury's estimate of what middle-income families pay in higher prices.
- **What stays fixed.** Companies are worth what they actually were, less the profit-share trim. In real life prices would also move the day the plan became believable; the Where it breaks section puts a number on that.
- **Dollars.** 2021-2025 figures are as paid each year. Year-twenty figures are in 2025 dollars.

All of it lives in Everybody_Owns_a_Piece_Backtest.xlsx in the SOMA folder: twelve tabs, live formulas, and a source ID on every typed-in number.

2021-2025, year by year

The fund paid every check from cash, and the trusts grew from 1.5% to 7.3% of the S&P 500. Dollars are as paid each year; the workbook's Backtest tab has every line behind these.

Line	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
S&P 500 total return	+28.7%	-18.1%	+26.3%	+25.0%	+17.9%
Trusts' combined stake	1.5%	3.0%	4.4%	5.9%	7.3%
Both trusts at Dec 31	$551B	$871B	$1,615B	$2,659B	$3,871B
Fund's cash in (its share of dividends and net buybacks)	$8.9B	$19.1B	$26.9B	$39.3B	$52.2B
Fund's checks paid	$6.5B	$16.4B	$19.4B	$32.1B	$49.5B
Cash coverage	1.35x	1.15x	1.36x	1.20x	1.04x
Fund check per person	$20	$49	$58	$94	$145
Carbon check per person	$506	$572	$587	$611	$654
Ad check per person	$130	$143	$152	$173	$197
Whole check per person	**$655**	**$764**	**$797**	**$878**	**$996**
Joe's profit share (Walmart)	$837	$772	$1,017	$1,215	$1,403
Joe's family of four, before costs	$3,457	$3,828	$4,203	$4,729	$5,386
Same, after higher carbon prices	$2,290	$2,508	$2,849	$3,319	$3,875
Joe's worker-trust slice at Dec 31	$1,226	$2,350	$3,983	$8,947	$14,003

Half of every check goes into a locked account. By the end of 2025 Joe and his wife had $7,549 locked and each kid $2,306, in 2025 dollars.

The run uses what companies were actually worth, less the 9% profit-share trim. If markets had priced in the shares still to come, prices would have run 18% to 21% lower, and the fund check with them: $119 instead of $145 in 2025. The cash would have been the same, so coverage would have been better, not worse.

2022, the built-in stress test. The S&P 500 lost 18.1%, and the plan barely felt it that year. The 2022 checks were set by the January 1 value, and companies paid owners more cash in 2022 than in 2021 ($1.28 trillion against $1.19 trillion, after the trim), so coverage held at 1.15x.

The hit came a year late: the 2023 fund check was $58 a person instead of about $73 had 2022 been flat. Both trusts still grew, from $551 billion to $871 billion, because a second year of new shares went in. Joe's profit share dipped from $837 to $772, and at Amazon it was zero, because Amazon lost money that year.

Where every dollar came from, and who gave up what

Over 2021-2025, $2.87 trillion of stock moved into the trusts, and 86% of it came from foreign investors and the top 10% of households. The new shares were worth $2.65 trillion when they went in. The other $0.22 trillion is mostly the trusts' stake in companies that joined the S&P 500 during the run; they were above the size line all along, so they issued too.

Group	Stock given up	Got from the citizen half	Net, citizen half only
Foreign investors	$766B	none	-$766B
Top 0.1% of households	$402B	$1.5B	-$400B
Next 0.9%	$486B	$13B	-$473B
Next 9%	$815B	$129B	-$686B
Next 40%	$367B	$574B	+$207B
Bottom 50%	$32B	$717B	+$685B
Total	**$2,868B**	**$1,434B**	

Households are ranked by net worth (Fed Distributional Financial Accounts). Their stock includes 401(k)s and IRAs, and pension and insurance holdings are spread over households by how much stock each group owns. The citizen half is split equally per household, a stand-in for equal per person.

The other $1,434 billion went to the worker trust. Who those workers are by wealth isn't in any public data, so it isn't assigned to a group here.

The other money pipes, 2021-2025:

Pipe	Total	Who pays
Profit share, upper bound	$1,678B	$1,325B out of shareholders′ after-tax profit, $352B out of corporate tax revenue, since it′s deductible pay. Covers every corporation and ignores the pay cap.
Carbon fee	$998B	Charged at the well and the mine, passed on in prices, and all of it, less a 1% collection cost, returned as checks. A middle-income family pays back about 57% of its check in higher prices (Treasury).
Ad levy	$268B	The platforms, with some passed on to advertisers and shoppers; how much isn′t modeled.
Citizen fund checks	$124B	The fund′s own share of dividends and net buybacks.

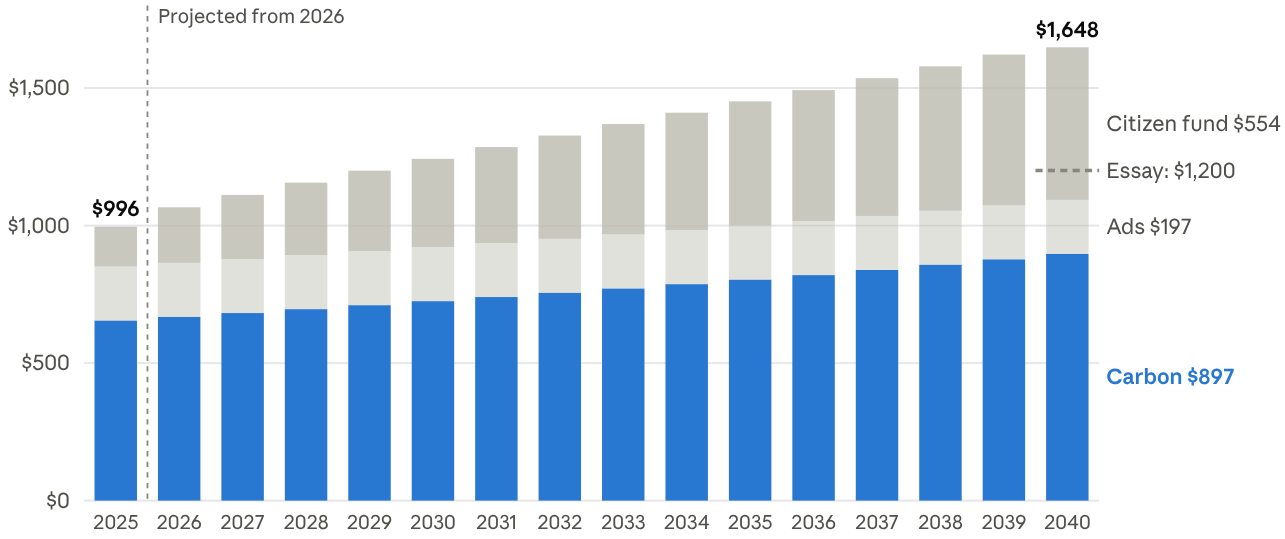
One pile isn′t used anywhere: wealth above the $1 billion ceiling. Forbes′s U.S. billionaires held $3.7 trillion above $1 billion each in 2021 and $5.9 trillion in 2025. The essay keeps it out of every check, and so does the run.

Out to year twenty

On the essay′s own no-growth path, the check reaches $1,648 a person in 2040, about $137 a month in 2025 dollars, and the trusts reach a quarter right on schedule if nobody leaves. The market path moves the fund line a lot and the whole check much less, because carbon and ads don′t depend on stock prices.

Carbon is the biggest piece of the check every year to 2040

Per person a year, 2025 dollars, essay's no-growth path. Carbon: 66% of the check in 2025, 54% in 2040.



Workbook, Year 20 tab, essay's path; 2025 is the Backtest's actual year; 2025 dollars

The ad line is held at its 2025 level, and the fund line is the only piece that moves with the stock market.

Path, 2026-2040 (2025 dollars)	Fund check 2030	Fund check 2040	Whole check 2040	Joe's family 2040, after carbon	Joe's worker-trust slice 2040
Essay's case: no growth in what companies are worth	$321	$554	$1,648	$5,924	$48,769
Middle of published forecasts (about 5% a year)	$322	$562	$1,656	$5,956	$49,515
Bull case (J.P. Morgan, 7.5% a year)	$353	$773	$1,867	$6,799	$69,599
Crash: down a third in 2026, never recovers	$214	$370	$1,463	$5,185	$32,500
AI boom (BlackRock scenario) through 2035	$484	$1,554	$2,647	$9,921	$136,619

The middle forecast lands on the essay's path for a plain reason. About 5% a year, less 2.4% inflation and the 2.7% companies pay out in cash, leaves almost no growth in what they're worth.

The fund runs short of cash from here. Its reserve runs out in 2028, and from then on it sells a little stock every year, $13 billion in 2030 and $23 billion in 2040, because companies now pay out 2.7% of their value and the check is 3%.

In 2040 the people who owned these companies in 2020 still hold 74.7% of them. On the essay's path the citizen trust is worth $6.5 trillion and the worker trust $6.7 trillion, and Joe and his wife have $49,789 locked.

Turnover moves the calendar and the split. At 5% a year the quarter takes 22 years, at 10% it takes 30, and at 20% it takes 39. At 10% the quarter ends up mostly citizen trust: 17.2% citizen, 7.8% worker.

Today's prices aren't a cautious base. The Shiller CAPE was about 40 at the end of 2025, against a long-run average of 17; at an average valuation the 2040 fund check would be $244, not $554.

Where it breaks

Of 18 things a fair critic would raise, one holds, four are serious, seven are design gaps the essay can close, four need better wording, and two can't be settled with public numbers. The Where it breaks tab has each one with live numbers.

Holds

- **The cash side.** In 2021-2025 a 3% check was paid out of what companies already pay their owners: the fund's share covered its checks 1.04x to 1.36x, 2022 included.

Serious

- **Somebody pays, all at once.** "A share issued isn't cash drained" is true for the company, not for its owners. Counting the new shares and the profit share, the bookkeeping puts existing shares 28% (nobody leaves) to 39% (10% turnover) lower the day the plan looks real, discounting at today's 2.7% cash yield; at 5% it's 25% to 30%. At 28% that's $16.6 trillion: $4.7 trillion of it foreign and $2.0 trillion from the middle 40% of households, much of it in 401(k)s and IRAs. About $1.1 trillion of the U.S. part is state and local pension money. *Fix: say it plainly. Phasing in doesn't avoid it, because markets price the whole path at once.*
- **Thin every year from here.** In 2025 covered companies paid owners 2.70% of their end-2025 value, and the check is 3%. At that rate the fund's cash covers 88% of its 2026 checks, so it sells some stock most years, and big tech is trading buybacks for AI

spending. *Fix: pay 3% of a five-year average value (Alaska's payout averages five years too), or the lesser of 3% and what came in plus the reserve.*

- **The legal road.** No court has ruled on forcing companies to issue shares to a government-created trust, and Horne v. Department of Agriculture (2015) treats a forced handover of personal property as a taking. Foreign investors would have given up $766 billion of the $2.87 trillion; few have treaty claims, but expect diplomatic pushback and less foreign appetite for U.S. stocks. *Fix: put the share rule in the same amendment as the ceiling, or write it as a tax paid in shares. This needs a constitutional lawyer, not a spreadsheet.*
- **Carbon carries the floor.** Carbon is 66% of the 2025 check and still bigger than the fund line in 2040 on the essay's path. Canada ended its rebate in 2025 even though, by Finance Canada's count, 8 in 10 families got back more than they paid. *Fix: lock the rebate in the amendment too, and show the floor without it.*

Design gaps

- **The worker half never stops.** At 10% turnover the trusts reach a quarter in year 30, the worker trust holds 7.8% instead of 12.7%, and top-ups run 0.83% of every company a year forever. The 2020 owners are down to 36% after 100 years. *Fix: vest worker shares over several years, pay them out at retirement, and cap the top-up; or say plainly that the worker half is a permanent stock grant of about half to one percent of every company a year.*
- **One rule, wildly different employers.** Worker trust per employee at year 20 if values stayed put: Kroger $11,316, Walmart $48,769, Amazon $180,762, Apple $2.79 million, Nvidia $12.4 million. The essay caps it per person but never sets the cap. *Fix: set it, with the overflow going to the citizen trust as the essay already says. Workers at small firms, governments and nonprofits get only the citizen half.*
- **The ad levy.** "Targeted" isn't measured anywhere, 30% is triple Maryland's top rate, and Maryland's smaller tax lost in tax court in August 2026 (on appeal). The ad check is $197 at 80% counted as targeted and about $148 with search ads left out, and a levy only on targeted ads pays companies to relabel them. *Fix: tax all digital ad revenue above a size line, with rising rates like Paul Romer's plan, and expect a First Amendment fight.*
- **Private companies and S corporations.** Private corporations' stock was worth $12.5 trillion at the end of 2025, $9.5 trillion of it in S corporations. Private values get gamed, private stock can't be sold in a thin year, and a citizen trust can't legally own S-corp

stock today. *Fix: start with public companies, add private ones later with a cash option, and make the trusts eligible S-corp holders, as ESOP trusts are.*

- **"Follows U.S. revenue" has no formula.** Does Toyota issue 1.5% of all of Toyota? Estimates of the S&P 500's revenue earned abroad run from 28% to 43%, and the answer moves the covered base by trillions. *Fix: write the rule; a U.S.-revenue share times 1.5% is the simplest.*
- **Checks and benefits.** Unless the law says otherwise, the check counts as income for SNAP, Medicaid and SSI, and it's taxable. Alaska's is, and Alaska spent $17.8 million in 2024 making up benefits its dividend cost people. *Fix: exclude it from every means test and from income tax, by statute.*
- **Voting power piles up.** Most fund investors never vote their own shares: about 23% of BlackRock's eligible assets and 4% of Vanguard's chose to. The trustees would end up voting most of a quarter of every big company, where Norway's fund averages 1.5% of a company and caps at 10%. *Fix: vote unvoted shares in proportion to the ones that are voted, and keep the trusts out of control fights.*

Fix the wording

- **The carbon line is gross.** A middle-income family pays back about 57% of its carbon check in higher prices. Joe's family got $2,022 in carbon checks in 2021, about $855 after prices. *Fix: show net numbers in the family table, and add Baker-Shultz's border adjustment so imports pay the same fee.*
- **The profit share is a tax on profit, aimed at the firm's own workers.** Shareholders keep about 71 cents of each pre-tax dollar instead of 79, and about 21% of the cost lands on tax revenue. At Walmart it's $1,403 per worker; at Amazon it was $0 in its 2022 loss year. *Fix: call it pay, and plan for the dodge: Mexico had to ban outsourcing in 2021 to stop firms routing around it.*
- **Today's prices aren't cautious.** The 2040 fund check is $554 at today's valuation and $244 at an average one. *Fix: call today's prices the middle case and show the average case beside it.*
- **It's a dividend, not a UBI.** $83 a month now, about $137 by 2040. *Fix: sell it as a floor of ownership, not income replacement (next sections).*

Can't settle with public numbers

- **Stock is taxed, debt isn't.** During the fill the plan works like a 1.5% yearly tax on owning big-company stock: about 29% of the middle forecast's 5.2% return, and about 54% of the return after inflation. Companies can shrink it with debt, stay private, or stay under

the line, and how much investment that costs isn't in public numbers. *Fix: base the issue on enterprise value, stock plus net debt, and keep the common-control and contractor rules.*

- **Behavior and law.** How companies, markets and courts would react (next section).

What the public numbers can't settle

These are questions of behavior and law, and no public dataset answers them, so the run doesn't guess.

- **How far prices would really fall.** The 28% to 39% is the bookkeeping value of the shares still to come. Real markets would also weigh the odds the plan passes, survives, or grows.
- **What the courts would do.** No case has tested a mandate to issue shares to a public trust.
- **What a 1.5% yearly levy on stock does to investment.** Companies could borrow more, stay private, stay under the line, or list abroad. The size of that response isn't measured anywhere.
- **Who works at covered companies, by wealth.** Without it, nobody can say how much of the worker half reaches the bottom half. The rough check on the Stress tests tab: the bottom half's share of wealth doubles by 2040 only if it holds about a quarter or more of the worker trust and other wealth barely grows, not counting fund units.
- **Whether profit sharing comes back out of pay.** French evidence says base pay mostly held up, except for high-skill workers, whose fixed pay fell to offset it.
- **Who really pays the ad levy, and what share of ads count as targeted.** Nobody publishes that split; the 80% here comes from the earlier model, because it's what the essay's $200 needs.
- **The social effects the essay hopes for.** Less crime, less shame, more people starting things. The essay already says these aren't in the numbers, and they aren't.

What this says about UBI, and AI's role

The plan is a dividend on ownership, not a basic income. It pays $83 a month per person at 2025 prices, about $137 by 2040 on the essay's path, and $221 if AI makes big companies worth nearly three times what they are now.

A basic income of $1,000 a month would take a $137 trillion fund paying 3%. That's 2.0 times every U.S.-listed company today; held as the citizen trust's 12.5% stake, those companies would have to be worth 16 times what they are.

So the plan doesn't replace a lost paycheck. If Joe had been laid off in 2025, his family's four checks would have continued at $3,983 a year before higher carbon prices, about $2,472 after, against the $45,000 he earned, and he'd keep his locked account and his $14,003 of worker-trust shares. A lost paycheck needs separate money, and this plan doesn't supply it.

What the numbers do support is the essay's narrower claim about AI: the citizen stake grows with what AI makes companies worth. In the AI boom path the fund line rises from $145 a person in 2025 to $1,554 in 2040, more than ten times, while the carbon and ad lines don't move with AI at all.

For the question people keep asking, that's a specific answer. AI's role here is to raise what everyone's shared stake is worth, to the extent it makes companies worth more, and to keep the books checkable. Neither one is an income.

Fixes that would make it sturdier, and small corrections

Five changes would close most of the gaps above, and ten small corrections would keep a critic from catching the essay on a fact.

1. **Smooth the payout.** Pay 3% of a five-year average value, or the lesser of 3% and the cash that came in plus the reserve.
2. **Say who pays.** Existing owners take the hit on day one, 401(k)s, pensions and foreign investors included. Put the 28% to 39% figure in the essay.
3. **Finish the worker half.** Vesting, payouts spread over years when people leave or retire, a per-person cap, and a cap on the top-up.
4. **Write the missing rules.** The U.S.-revenue formula, the ad-levy base, enterprise value as the base for the issue, S-corp eligibility, pass-through voting, and keeping the check out of means tests and income tax.
5. **Lock the carbon rebate with the payout rule,** and show the floor with and without it.

Corrections to the essay:

- **Bottom half's wealth.** "About 2.5 percent" is now 2.4% at the end of 2025 and 2.3% in mid-2026, per the Fed.

- **Giving Pledge.** "Nearly four times richer" holds before inflation, a 283% gain; after inflation it's about 2.7 times.
- **Pew.** The 71% expect fewer jobs "over the next two decades"; the timeframe belongs in the sentence.
- **Sanders's bill.** "Every big AI company" means more than $200 million a year in AI revenue, and for mixed companies only the AI business.
- **The MIT island study.** The researchers ran 13 copies of the agent, each for 30 hours, not one agent.
- **"335 million owners."** The Census counted 341.8 million people in July 2025.
- **The table.** It holds carbon at $500 though the fee climbs; the run has $725 in year 10 and $897 in year 20. The ad line starts at $154 in 2025 dollars, not $200, and Joe's profit share at Walmart ran $772 to $1,403 as paid, never $1,600.
- **"The fund line roughly doubles."** At J.P. Morgan's 7.5% a year it ends at 1.39 times the no-growth case; doubling takes the AI boom.
- **"In a thin year the fund sells a little stock."** At today's payout rates it sells some most years.
- **"Every number above is cautious on purpose."** Today's prices are near a record valuation, so they're the middle case at best.

Sources

The workbook's Sources tab lists all 55 sources with the exact table, line or quote used. The main ones:

- Companies and payouts: S&P Dow Jones Indices buyback releases for 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; Market Attributes, December 2025; SIFMA Capital Markets Fact Book 2026; SEC EDGAR filings for the eight employers; BEA corporate profits via FRED
- Who owns what: Fed Financial Accounts, Z.1; Fed Distributional Financial Accounts; 2025 Survey of Consumer Finances; Forbes U.S. billionaires
- People and prices: Census population estimates, Vintage 2025; CPI-U via FRED; CBO Demographic Outlook
- Carbon and ads: EIA Monthly Energy Review, Table 11.1; Climate Leadership Council, Exceeding Paris; Treasury OTA Working Paper 115; Finance Canada on ending the consumer carbon price; IAB/PwC internet ad revenue; Maryland's ad tax at the 4th Circuit and the Tax Court; Paul Romer's ad tax

- Forecasts and valuation: Vanguard; J.P. Morgan LTCMA; BlackRock capital market assumptions; Shiller CAPE
- Design and law: 26 U.S.C. 409 and NCEO on ESOP buybacks; Horne v. Department of Agriculture; Moore v. United States; BlackRock Voting Choice; Alaska PFD tax information; BLS labor share
- Essay fact checks (Sources tab S46 and S52-S55): IPS, The Giving Pledge at 15; Pew; S. 4825; Gizmodo on the MIT island study; Fed bottom-half wealth share via FRED